The name 'bisque' refers to a rich and luxurious shellfish soup with cream and brandy and is thought to have come from the Spanish Biscay region.

lobster bisque

SERVES 4 **PREP** 45 MINS **COOK** 1 HR 10 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

1 lobster, cooked, about 2¼lb (1kg) in weight
3½ tbsp butter
1 onion, finely chopped
1 carrot, finely chopped
2 celery ribs, finely chopped
1 leek, finely chopped
½ fennel bulb, finely chopped
1 bay leaf
1 sprig of tarragon
2 garlic cloves, crushed
2½oz (75g) tomato purée
4 tomatoes, coarsely chopped
½ cup Cognac or brandy
½ cup dry white wine or vermouth
1¾ quarts (1¾ liters) fish stock
½ cup heavy cream
salt and freshly ground black pepper
pinch of cayenne
juice of ½ lemon
chives, to garnish

1 Split the lobster in half, remove the meat from the body, and chop the meat into small pieces. Twist off the claws and legs, break at the joints, and remove the meat, then crack all the shells with the back of a knife. Chop the shells into coarse pieces and put the meat into the refrigerator.

2 Melt the butter in a large pan over medium heat, add the vegetables, herbs, and garlic, and cook for 10 minutes, or until softened, stirring occasionally. Add the lobster shells. Stir in the tomato purée, tomatoes, Cognac, white wine, and fish stock. Bring to a boil and simmer for 1 hour.

3 Let cool slightly, then ladle into a food processor. Process in short bursts, until the shell breaks into very small pieces. Strain through a coarse sieve, pushing through as much as you can, then pass it again through a fine sieve before returning to the heat.

4 Bring to a boil, add the reserved lobster meat and the cream, then season to taste, adding the cayenne and lemon. Serve in warm bowls, garnished with chives.